

JAPAN'S SACRED TEMPLES

Zenkoji

善光寺 | NAGANO, JAPAN

For fourteen centuries, nobody has seen the Buddha inside Zenkoji — not the pilgrims, and not its own priests. What grew up around that absence is a temple you perform, not one you look at.

JAPAN'S SACRED TEMPLES / VOLUME ONE

Before you go

Admission fees, opening hours and access arrangements described in this book are subject to change. Check the official site before you travel: zenkoji.jp

The Buddha Nobody Has Seen

Zenkoji has kept its central image out of sight for fourteen centuries, from pilgrims and from its own clergy alike. What has grown up around that absence is a temple you perform rather than one you look at.

Nobody at Zenkoji has seen the temple's Buddha. Not the visitors, which is unremarkable, and not the priests who conduct the morning service, which is not. The image is an absolute hidden buddha, a *zettai hibutsu*, and the rule admits no seniority: the chief priest is no more entitled to a look than you are.

Behind the doors, by tradition, is a triad — Amida with Kannon and Seishi, the three of them sharing one halo — brought from Baekje in 552 with the first consignment of Buddhism to reach Japan, which would make it the oldest Buddhist image in the country. That is transmitted account rather than documented fact, and the temple does not pretend otherwise.

Consider what that leaves a place drawing some of the largest visitor numbers in Japan. There is nothing at the centre to look at. So the temple long ago rearranged itself around verbs. Turn this. Rub that. Find the five doves. Walk into a corridor with no light in it and keep your right hand on the wall until you touch metal.

Fourteen hundred years of that habit have left marks in the woodwork, and the marks are the point.



Looking through the gate towards the main hall, incense rising from the burner at the centre of the approach. There is nothing at the far end for a visitor to look at — the image inside has never been seen by anyone.

An image that arrived in a canal

The founding story is not a dignified one, and Zenkoji tells it anyway.

When the new religion reached the court the Soga were for it and the Mononobe against, and when plague broke out the opposition threw the image into the Horie canal at Naniwa, present-day Osaka. Honda Yoshimitsu, a retainer of the governor of Shinano who was up in the capital on business, fished it out and carried it home. It was enshrined near what is now Iida, moved to this site in 642, and given a hall by imperial decree in 644. The temple took his name. Not the emperor's, not the clan's: the provincial servant's.

The image, being invisible, multiplied. Several hundred temples around the country hold a copy of the one-halo triad. An icon nobody may look at turns out to be exceptionally portable.

A note — the shape of the hidden triad

By tradition the image is Amida flanked by Kannon and Seishi, the three sharing a single halo — the “one-halo triad” form that gives its name to every copy enshrined elsewhere in Japan. Nobody now living has confirmed the shape by sight; the description is inherited, not observed.

Two mountains, one building

Zenkoji belongs to no school of Buddhism. It is an independent foundation held jointly by two head temples of different denominations: Daikanjin, which is Tendai, and Daihongan, which is Jōdo and, unusually for a house of this rank, a convent. Twenty-five Tendai sub-temples stand behind the one, fourteen Jōdo halls behind the other.

Two schools sharing custody of one building is the sort of arrangement that normally ends in litigation. Here it ends in the morning service, held daily without exception at an hour that moves with the sunrise, near 5.30 in summer and 7.00 in winter, in which each school performs its own liturgy, back to back, with no gap between them.



The bronze ox in the temple grounds, with its explanatory plaque. It commemorates the proverb overleaf — an accidental pilgrimage that became the nation's shorthand for a lucky mistake.

The absence of a sect is also the absence of a gate: men and women, any rank, no questions asked. Out of that came the phrase that fixed the place in the national imagination — *however far, go once to Zenkoji*. It helped that the Hokkoku Kaidō — the highway that splits off the Nakasendō at Oiwake and runs north to the Japan Sea — went straight through the temple town on its way. Salvation and logistics rarely part company.

The other proverb is better. *Drawn to Zenkoji by an ox* describes an old woman with no religion in her, whose drying cloth caught on the horn of a passing beast; she chased it, arrived here, kept a night's vigil and acquired the faith she had never wanted. The phrase is still ordinary Japanese for an accident that turns out well. The national saying about the country's great pilgrimage temple is about getting there by mistake. There is a bronze ox in the grounds, with a plaque, in case you miss it.

Two head temples, no sect, and a national proverb about arriving by accident. What holds the place together, as the next section shows, is not doctrine but a piece of architecture built for exactly that purpose.

The corridor with no light in it

The *okaidan-meguri* runs beneath the inner sanctuary. You go down, the door closes, and the darkness is total: not gloom, not dim, but the complete absence of light, which most adults have never actually experienced. Right hand on the wall, and walk.

Somewhere along the passage, directly below the hidden image, your fingers find a piece of iron. This is the lock of paradise, and touching it is held to bind you to the Buddha above. Then you carry on, in the dark, until the stairs come up under your feet.

That is the argument of Zenkoji in ninety seconds. The image cannot be seen, so it is approached from underneath, by hand, without light. Photographs are no use to you here, and neither is my prose.

The hall above was rebuilt in 1707 after something over a dozen fires (the count varies by source) and made a National Treasure in 1953. Seen from above it forms a T, a long worship hall grafted onto the front of the sanctuary, a plan named for the mallet used to strike a temple bell. It is among the largest wooden buildings in eastern Japan, and built for depth rather than display: the outer hall, where anyone at all may sit, runs back without interruption towards the part nobody may see.



The main hall seen past a stone lantern, worshippers under umbrellas in the foreground. The layered roofline of the T-shaped plan is visible from this angle.



The hall seen whole, framed by a large pine. The depth of the building — worship hall grafted onto sanctuary — reads clearly in a single frame.

Turn it, rub it, find it

East of the gate stands the sutra repository, begun in 1754 and dedicated in 1759, fifteen and a half metres to a side and seventeen high under a pyramidal roof of cypress bark. Inside is an octagonal revolving bookcase three metres across, holding the 6,771 scrolls of the Buddhist canon. Push it once, clockwise, and you are credited with having read all of it.

As theology, generous. As an argument about what a temple is for, it is the dark corridor again: the merit is in the doing.



The sutra repository, seen from an angle that shows the pyramidal cypress-bark roof and the timber walls.
Photo: Jnn, CC BY 2.1, via Wikimedia Commons.



The revolving bookcase inside, gilded and holding the full Buddhist canon. One clockwise turn stands in for reading all 6,771 scrolls.
Image provided by Michael G. Khmel'nitsky.
<http://www.mig81.com>

The rest of the visit runs the same way. High on the gate of 1750 hangs a plaque bearing the temple's three characters with five doves concealed in them, and the first character is said to resemble the face of an ox; visitors stand in the lane with their heads back, counting. In the outer hall sits Binzuru, the arhat you touch where your own body hurts, polished by several centuries of arthritic hands. Before the gate sits a bronze Enmei Jizō of some 2.7 metres, cast around 1722 and left out in the weather, which is how he came to be called the Wet Buddha. At the foot of the lane, the outer gate of 1918 carries guardians by Takamura Kōun and Yonehara Unkai that stand without props, balanced on their own centre lines.



The gate plaque, photographed through the netting that keeps birds off it. Five doves are worked into the three characters — visitors count them from the lane below.



The Wet Buddha — an outdoor Enmei Jizō, cast around 1722 and never given shelter. Photo: 663highland, CC BY 2.5, via Wikimedia Commons.

Even the paving is participatory: donated by an Edo merchant in 1714, and said to run to 7,777 stones between the entrance and the main hall. The fifty or sixty shopfronts along its two hundred metres sell prayer beads, soba and *oyaki*, the greens-filled dumpling of the province. The votive rack carries the usual five-sided tablets and also a run of Rilakkuma ones, asking for examination success and protection from misfortune. An institution that has spent fourteen hundred years not turning people away is unlikely to be troubled by a cartoon bear.



The 1918 outer gate. Its guardian figures, by Takamura Kōun and Yonehara Unkai, stand unsupported through balance alone.



The votive rack: traditional five-sided tablets hang beside a run decorated with the cartoon bear Rilakkuma, asking the same favours as everything around them.

The eighth of May, 1847

The worst thing that ever happened here happened at the busiest possible hour.

An estimated magnitude 7.4 earthquake struck directly beneath northern Shinano while a public showing was in progress and the temple town was full. Of the seven to eight thousand people lodging there, nine in ten died. The regional toll passed twelve thousand. A landslide dammed the Sai river; nineteen days later it gave way and flooded the land downstream.

The main hall, the gate and the repository were all standing that morning, and are standing now.

A note — a modern problem with an early example

Disaster researchers still reach for 1847 now and again, a pilgrimage town destroyed at peak season being a thoroughly modern problem with a very early example. What made Zenkoji famous is what filled those inns.

The next great airing is scheduled for 4 April to 19 June 2027, seventy-seven days, during which a pillar is raised in front of the hall for people to touch and the substitute image is shown. Note the wording. Even at the temple's own unveiling, what is unveiled is a stand-in, and what the queue is for is a piece of wood you can put your hand on.

Come then for the crowds. Come in any other year for the temple.

The Particulars

GETTING THERE

Everything begins at JR Nagano Station, reachable from Tokyo Station on the Hokuriku Shinkansen (the fastest *Kagayaki* services take around eighty minutes). From stand 1 at the Zenkoji exit, an Alpico bus reaches Zenkoji Daimon in eight to ten minutes for ¥190, leaving a ten-minute walk up the approach; the Gururin-gō loop bus goes from stand 4. On foot it is about thirty minutes from the station to the main hall, the last stretch being the temple lane itself, which is the correct way to arrive.

ADMISSION AND HOURS

The precincts are open around the clock and free, as is the outer hall. A ticket is needed for the inner sanctuary and the dark corridor, the gate, the repository and the museum; the machine stands to the right of the main hall's front. Combined ticket ¥1,500 for adults, ¥600 for secondary-school pupils, ¥200 for primary, free below that; separately, inner sanctuary with corridor ¥800, gate ¥800, repository ¥500. Prices and ticket types were revised on 1 April 2026, so older sources still quote the previous ¥1,200 combined fare. The inner sanctuary opens an hour before the morning service and closes at 16.30 from April to October, 16.15 in March and November, 16.00 from December to February; gate, repository and museum run 09.00 to 16.00. Fees and opening hours change; check the official site before you travel: zenkoji.jp

HOW LONG

An hour for the main hall and the dark corridor. Ninety minutes to two hours to add the lane and the upper storey of the gate. Two to three hours to take in the repository, the museum and the two head temples properly. The corridor draws a queue; the quietest moment is straight after the morning service.

WHEN

Spring for blossom on the approach, and for the airing if the year is right. Summer for the dawn service, when the walk up is cool. Autumn for red maple against the timber of the gate and repository. Winter for snow banked on the main hall's cypress-bark roof, with the caveat that the new-year bell and first visit draw some of the largest crowds in the country.

NEARBY

Daihongan and Daikanjin, the two head temples, both with gardens and treasure halls. Joyama Park immediately east: the oldest park in the city, some 470 cherry trees, and the Nagano Prefectural Art Museum with its Higashiyama Kaii gallery. Further out by bus, Matsushiro, an Edo castle town with Sanada holdings. Below the temple, Yawataya Isogorō has been blending its seven-spice mixture (chilli, citrus peel, sesame, sanshō, ginger, shiso and hemp seed) since 1736, and will mix you a custom ratio.

Credits and notes

Image credits

Most of the photographs in this book were taken by the author. Three images are drawn from Wikimedia Commons under Creative Commons Attribution licences or a custom attribution licence granted by the photographer; copyright in each remains with its photographer or rights holder.

Zenkoji Kyoza (Sutra Repository) — Jnn, CC BY 2.1, via Wikimedia Commons

Zenkoji Nurebotoke (Enmei Jizo) — 663highland, CC BY 2.5, via Wikimedia Commons

Image provided by Michael G. Khmel'nitsky. <http://www.mig81.com>

All other photographs — Photography by the author.

CC BY 2.1: <https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.1/jp/>

CC BY 2.5: <https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.5/>

About the information in this book

Admission fees, opening hours and access arrangements are subject to change. Always check the official website of Zenkoji before you travel: zenkoji.jp. The information here reflects the time of writing, and no guarantee is made as to its accuracy or completeness.

Terms of use

This book is licensed for the **personal use of the purchaser**.

Redistribution, reposting, or commercial use of this file is not permitted.

Copyright in the photographs remains with their respective photographers and rights holders.

Principal sources

Zenkoji official site — <https://www.zenkoji.jp/>

Zenkoji, admission guide — <https://www.zenkoji.jp/meguru/sanpai/>

Cultural Heritage Online (Agency for Cultural Affairs, Japan) — designation records for the main hall, gate and sutra repository

Cabinet Office, Government of Japan — disaster-prevention information page, report on the 1847 Zenkoji earthquake

Japan's Sacred Temples — Zenkoji

Japan's Sacred Temples, Volume One

One temple, one book — a digital guide series visiting Japan's great temples in turn. The first is Zenkoji, in Nagano: a temple with no sect of its own, which for nearly fourteen hundred years has been the one that everyone was told to visit "at least once, however far."